

The Obligation Mosaic: Race and Social Norms in US Political Participation

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CHAPTER

Two The Racialized Norms Model

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Abstract

Collective action inherently involves costs and the problem of free-riding, and yet some people engage in politics. This chapter provides a review of the literature from the rational choice and social psychology traditions, which suggests that selective incentives and social norms help explain why some people participate in politics. Joining these traditions with a theory of groups, the chapter presents the racialized norms model: because of divergence in historical group context and continued racial segregation in present-day social context, racial groups in the United States are likely to face differences in social incentives and norms when choosing whether to engage in politics, in addition to differences in entrenched costs. A set of testable implications is outlined.

Keywords: free riding, collective action, costs, rational choice, social norms, segregation, social context, racialized norms model, selective incentives, social psychology

Subject: US Politics

Why do some people participate in politics, while others stay home? What produces group-level trends in participation if not resources alone? I introduce the racialized norms model, a novel theory of political participation that links the micro mechanisms of participation with the macro forces of America's racialized society. The RNM anticipates that social norms matter for involvement in politics but the content and enforcement of these norms varies across racial groups due to both historical social context and present-day racial segregation. The framework allows us to anticipate when and where divergence in norms will emerge and produces a set of testable implications I outline at the conclusion of this chapter and engage with over the remainder of the book.

Calculating Costs and Benefits

A framework developed over fifty years ago provides a starting point for our exploration of why some people participate in politics while others do not. Presented first by Anthony Downs (1957) and Mancur Olson (1965), this framework argues that three variables are central for understanding participatory choices: the costs associated with participating, the possible benefits from involvement, and the (perceived) likelihood one's engagement will affect the outcome (Blais, 2000; Downs, 1957; Olson, 1965; Riker and Ordeshook, 1968). Each of these considerations alone has spurred entire traditions of research (e.g., Blais, 2000; Fraga, 2018; Gomez, Hansford, and Krause, 2007; Haspel and Knotts, 2005; Soss, 2002; Verba, Schlozman, and Brady, 1995), but together, the three variables produce a puzzle for social scientists studying political participation that they have tried to solve since its inception.

Let's start by considering costs. Engaging in politics takes time and money, among other resources, all of which disincentivize engagement in the democratic process. Even voting, a relatively simple and straightforward act, requires large amounts of resolve and planning. An eligible citizen must be properly registered, needs to know an election is taking place, must collect information about the candidates, has to find time and transportation to travel to the polls, needs to provide a valid photo identification with a matching address in some states, and often, must wait in line during a workday to cast a ballot. These resources and information costs add up, especially for busy, distracted Americans with families, jobs, health challenges, and a wealth of alternative leisure activities on which to spend their time.

But the substantive benefits of political participation—our second bin of considerations—surely outweigh the costs, an advocate of the democratic process might say. After all, think of everything at stake if one can influence how the government levies its power: access to clean water, a qualified police force, public high schools, and the assurance that everything from airplanes to swing sets meet certain standards of safety, just to name a few. Policy outcomes on these issues, along with the thousands of others considered by government officials each year, have the ability to dramatically improve—or undermine—the quality of individuals' lives. Surely, these expansive and impactful potential benefits outweigh the rather trivial costs of participating, right?

Not so fast, scholars embedded in this framework would say. Instrumental benefits that people wish to achieve when they engage in politics have a number of properties that mitigate their centrality in the decision process. First, the achievement of them is uncertain. Competing interests in the public sphere mean that political participation comes with relatively little assurance of return on investment. Even large-scale social movements that persist over time and involve many organized interests are usually only partially successful in implementing their goals (Gillion, 2013; Hogan, 2007). Uncertainty about the outcome and the low likelihood that any individual's unique contribution will be the deciding factor reduces the power of substantive benefits to motivate action (Downs, 1957; Olson, 1965; Riker and Ordeshook, 1968).

Second, most political goods are *collective* in nature. They require many people working together to achieve but, once enacted, are widely shared (Olson, 1965; Salisbury, 1969). The collective nature of the final good means that an individual could, theoretically, achieve all the benefits of government without lifting a finger. If others coordinate, endure the costs of participation, and are successful, even an individual who stays at home watching television while a revolution wages on will still receive the benefits. The collective nature of the final goods, along with uncertainty about outcomes, incentivizes *free riding*: individuals reason that they can achieve all the benefits without any of the costs by letting others do the work.

Together, the element of uncertainty, the low likelihood that one's actions will be decisive, and the collective nature of the final good comprise our third bin of participatory considerations in classic models: the perception that one's political participation will matter. Formalized in scholarship by rational-choice theorists in the mid-twentieth century, this *logic of collective action* and the *calculus of voting* lead to a rather dismal conclusion:

political participation is almost always irrational, with the costs outweighing the benefits, and even under the best of circumstances, likely will not occur (Downs, 1957; Olson, 1965; Riker and Ordeshook, 1968).¹ These foundational texts have gone on to become a standard part of the political behavior canon, included in syllabi across the country and incorporated into multiple disciplines. Their proliferation reflects their persuasiveness; the arguments are compelling and logical and challenge social scientists of all stripes to think through the various components of the participatory process instead of just assuming involvement is natural or inevitable as some of the earliest theorists did (de Tocqueville, [1835–40] 2000; Madison, [1787] 2004).

And yet, to optimists—like me²—and to practitioners who come to this puzzle with decades of organizing work behind them, the logic of collective action, its assumptions, and the resulting conclusion may seem intuitively incorrect. Or at least incomplete. After all, history is full of moments when activists like James Lawson, Ella Baker, and Delores Huerta joined with countless others to seek a new distribution of power and resources in American society (Hogan, 2007; Keyssar, 2009; McAdam, 1988; Takaki, 2008). These individuals were willing to absorb even huge costs in pursuit of uncertain, collective goods—facing violence, prison time, and financial distress. But these pioneers of justice are not alone. Other Americans, too, regularly absorb smaller costs to engage in collective action. For instance, between 3 and 6 million Americans turned out to participate in the 2017 Women’s March (↪ Chenoweth and Pressman, 2017), nearly half the eligible population showed up at the polls in the 2018 midterm election (McDonald, 2018), and 14% of Americans reported donating to a political campaign in 2017 (*The Public, the Political System and American Democracy*, 2018). The logic of collective action suggests that people should never participate in politics—and yet, sometimes, they do.

So what’s missing from this classic formulation of political participation? What other factors might encourage people to engage in politics? One answer to these questions is that not all the benefits of political participation come from political outcomes (Chong, 1991; Riker and Ordeshook, 1968; Uhlaner, 1986; Uhlaner, Cain, and Kiewiet, 1989). Rather, a number of benefits can come from engaging in the process itself and may encourage individuals to participate. These benefits do not face the same constraints of uncertainty and collectivism that the instrumental benefits do. Rather than being collective, they are *selective*: individuals get them if and only if they show up (Chong, 1991; Riker and Ordeshook, 1968; Salisbury, 1969). As a result, selective benefits are not weighted against the likelihood that a political goal is achieved and so can more fully offset inherent costs.

I often explain selective versus instrumental benefits to my students like this. In the classic framework, an individual goes to a political rally to achieve a collective good—say, universal health care. This outcome suffers from all the problems we’ve discussed: it is uncertain, hinges on the participation of many people, is costly, and encourages free riding. But there are other reasons to go to a political rally, above and beyond the instrumental purpose of the event. An individual might want the free T-shirt that is being handed out by the organizers (a material benefit). Or she might go to find new, like-minded friends who are also attending the event (a social benefit). Or the person might attend the rally just to feel good about herself and the democratic process afterward (a psychological benefit). Each of these benefits exists apart from the actual outcome of the rally—that is, whether it is effective at achieving universal health care—and as a result, does not suffer from the free-rider problem.

Accounting for these selective benefits—both intrinsic and extrinsic—fundamentally changes the calculus of engagement. Instrumental, outcome-based benefits begin to matter only so far as they opt people into a pool of possible participants. After that, who shows up depends on the trade-off between inherent costs and selective rewards. When the ↪ benefits—social, psychological, material—outweigh the costs, people engage in politics.

The selective benefits approach to solving the collective action problem, as well as the collective action problem itself, fit squarely within a *rational-choice framework*. As part of this theoretical umbrella, people are believed to act as human calculators, identifying their goals, weighing the costs and benefits of each action, and enacting the most effective solution.³ But there’s another way to think about selective benefits that comes from a rich

literature in social psychology, not economics. This literature centers on groups, norms, and social processes in explaining the seemingly irrational behavior of human beings. And in doing so, it comes to many of the same conclusions.

The Centrality of the Social

While economists, political scientists, and sociologists in the midtwentieth century worked to solve the collective action problem, psychologists just across campus were interested in a different—but it turns out, fundamentally related—question: Why do people sometimes do seemingly irrational things, especially when surrounded by peers? In a discipline-changing set of early studies, Solomon Asch (1955) and Leon Festinger (1957), among others, demonstrated that social information and expectations powerfully shape human cognition and behavior. Information from peers can make everyday people ignore clear indications of danger and provide incorrect answers to questions with straightforward solutions (Asch, 1955; Latane and Darley, 1968). Further, this social information is only selectively absorbed: individuals are more likely to model their behaviors on those similar to them in salient ways rather than unlike them (Festinger, 1954). Far from a rational calculator, this scholarship suggested that the human brain is easily—overwhelmingly—influenced by the *need to belong*. Attitudes and behaviors that subsequently follow are founded on this social information, even if false or inefficient.

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Much like early studies on the irrationality of collective action established a cottage industry of political behavior scholarship, these foundational works changed the trajectory of psychology. In centering the group in human cognition rather than the individual, a new subdiscipline—social psychology—was born, and from it, sixty years of scholarship have proliferated (Ross, Lepper, and Ward, 2010). Now, a rich literature across disciplines shows that groups serve as a fundamental organizing principle for the human mind (e.g., Enos, 2017; Hogg, 2003; Kinder and Kam, 2010; Tajfel and Turner, 1986). Even arbitrary and momentary groups can orient behavior and attitudes, but socially salient groups—ones that exist across contexts and over time—are even more central, developing into an individual's sense of self and identity (Ellemers, Spears, and Doosje, 2002; Hogg, 2003; Tajfel and Turner, 1986).

Central to the process of translating the psychology of groups to the behavior of individuals are social norms, or the unwritten rules and habits of a group. These social norms communicate both average and aspirational group behavior. They tell individuals—often subconsciously—how to fit in, act effectively, garner respect, and be good (Cialdini and Trost, 1998; Tankard and Paluck, 2015). In doing so, groups and their social norms solve a more fundamental human cognition problem. The world is wildly complicated with endless sources of information. Using social categories and the norms associated with them can help focus the information that is relevant and useful and, in doing so, render an incredibly complex world more manageable (Dawson, 1994; Hogg, 2003).

Social psychologists generally sort norms into three categories, based on their purposive usefulness to human beings and how they affect behavior (Cialdini and Trost, 1998). First, social norms can provide information about effective action. In a world of uncertainty, people must quickly consume information from their environment and make choices about how to behave. Through observing the behavior of others, people obtain “social proof” regarding effective actions for achieving certain goals and mimic that behavior. These *descriptive norms* capture the average behavior of a group or environment (Aarts and Dijksterhuis, 2003; Cialdini, Reno, and Kallgren, 1990; Gerber and Rogers, 2009). They work as a heuristic for how to behave, especially in situations that are novel, uncertain, or ambiguous (Cialdini and Trost, 1998).

Second, social norms help actors build and maintain relationships. While Maslow's 1943 hierarchy of needs places food and shelter on the bottom two tiers, decades of social psychological research have confirmed the importance (and sheer force) of the desire to belong, a need that often trumps more fundamental resources

(Crandall, 1988; Uhlaner, 1986). *Injunctive norms*, the second type of norm, serve to capture this dynamic, illustrating the valued social behaviors of a group. Injunctive norms speak not necessarily to what behaviors are practiced, as descriptive norms do, but rather what behaviors *should be* practiced. While descriptive norms function largely off a need to gather information and act upon it, the force of injunctive norms is motivated by the promise of social rewards and sanctions (Cialdini and Trost, 1998). Thus, while actors following descriptive norms will migrate toward the mean behavior of a group, actors adopting injunctive norms migrate toward the behavior of prototypes, or individuals identified as normatively good who represent the group ideal (Morrison and Miller, 2008).

Finally, social norms serve a central role in building and managing self-concept. Norms that are wholly external originally can become *personal norms*, internalized through the development of either morality or identity (Morris et al., 2015; Schwartz, 1977; Thøgersen, 2006). Identities, derived largely from external feedback regarding worth and social categorization, help individuals to both understand their relevant categories of comparison and anticipate the actions and reactions of others (Tajfel and Turner, 1986). Once an identity is established, people engage in actions and embrace attitudes that conform to that identity in an attempt to decrease self-concept distress (Hogg, 2003; Tajfel and Turner, 1986). Thus actions that were once guided by external norms—and the promise of either social rewards or sanctions—become internally motivated. These personal norms function as a kind of internalized panopticon, guided by the desire to avoid cognitive dissonance and guilt or affirm one's sense of self. Scholars have shown that these personal norms are powerful predictors of other-regarding behaviors (Thøgersen, 2006).

The influence of all three types of social norms on human behavior has been demonstrated in contexts as varied as amusement parks, elementary schools, hotel rooms, libraries, and sororities, to name a few (Aarts and Dijksterhuis, 2003; Cialdini, Reno, and Kallgren, 1990; Crandall, 1988; Goldstein, Cialdini, and Giskevicius, 2008; Westphal and Bednar, 2005). Within these contexts, researchers have shown how behaviors spread through social networks and that norms-based interventions can change behavior in prosocial directions (Crandall, 1988; Larson and Lewis, 2017; Paluck and Green, 2009; Perkins, Craig, and Perkins, 2011). Messages aimed at updating information about average behavior, changing prototypical references, or adding social observation are all proven methods for influencing outcomes (Tankard and Paluck, 2015).

This influence also extends to political outcomes. In recent years, a persuasive set of studies has shown that social information and social pressure alter a wide range of political behaviors. This includes turnout, vote choice, and even more costly forms of political involvement (e.g., Bond et al., 2012; McClendon, 2014; McKenzie, 2004; Sinclair, 2012; White, Laird, and Allen, 2014; White and Laird, 2020). Through novel field and lab experiments as well as observational work, we have learned that messages threatening neighborly observation increase turnout significantly more than alternatives (Gerber, Green, and Larimer, 2008), that political giving to campaigns and candidates is a function of peer networks (Sinclair, 2012), and that providing opportunities to publicize participation increases involvement in even contentious political activities (McClendon, 2014). In each of these situations, individuals face costs for participating—sometimes even relatively high costs—but expanding the opportunities for social rewards or levying the threat of social sanctions changes the calculus of political involvement and can increase participation.

Here is where the literature on social psychology connects—I think quite beautifully—with a rational-choice framework of political behavior. The collective action problem and its proposed solutions suggest that selective incentives encourage engagement in politics; work from social psychology tells us the need to belong powerfully shapes behavior. Together, these two literatures teach us that social and psychological benefits in particular may be a potent part of the participatory process. Yes, political participation is costly, and yes, governmental outcomes are often uncertain, but the anticipation of social and psychological rewards in the form of acceptance, respect, or self-concept management that come through the process of participating may overwhelm these costs and uncertainties. Social information, standards, and expectations are central parts of

human behavior and must be considered when evaluating why people do anything, including participate in politics.

Building a Theory of Groups

This is usually where the story ends. Benefits from participating that exist outside the actual substantive outcome of politics help to motivate political action, solving the participatory paradoxes put forward by Downs and Olson. Social benefits—or the promise of social sanctions—prove especially powerful for this. Scholars have demonstrated time and again that the application of social pressure and observation can increase engagement ↴ in politics. We have from these two traditions a strong understanding of why *individuals* engage in politics.

But what about *groups*? How do we explain variation across politically relevant cleavages in American society—like the ones we observe with respect to race—using this framework? So far, we can't. Reflecting the psychological tradition it pulls from, work on social norms and political participation has focused primarily on testing the *micro mechanisms* of political participation. That is, scholars concentrate on a specific group and setting where they assume political participation is socially valued and then use a lab or field experiment to isolate how pressure, information, or observation change what individuals do politically within that setting.

If we want to explain across-group variation, though, we will need more than this. We need to determine whether the participatory factors we have identified as so influential for political participation vary in their presence, effect, or form across types of people. We need a theory of groups that goes beyond assuming people seek acceptance from them to one that anticipates how macro forces might systematically shape the content and enforcement of participatory social norms across them.

For this, we turn to two new literatures, one in sociology on racial segregation and a second on the history of race in America, that show how institutional constraints and experiences vary by racial group. Both of these literatures identify characteristics of American society that divide and define peoples. Racial segregation creates geographic, social, and psychological space between members of different groups, allowing for norms to develop and be enforced dissimilarly. Distinct histories infuse membership with meaning, producing divergence in the content of group-based social norms. In joining these two literatures with that we already know about the micro mechanisms of social pressure, we are able to build a theory of norm divergence in the United States that explains both individual and group-based patterns.

Racial Segregation

For most of the nation's history, and still today, individuals of different racial groups occupy remarkably separate social spaces (Jargowsky, 1996; Logan, 2011; Massey and Denton, 1993). Racial groups in the United States, on average, live in separate neighborhoods, attend different schools, consume different media, and form close ties with those ↴ who primarily share their own race (Dougherty, 2003; Logan and Stults, 2011; McPherson, Smith-Lovin, and Cook, 2001; Reardon, Yun, and McNulty Eitle, 2000). Despite the work of activists over decades to deconstruct the legacies of residential and institutional segregation, these patterns persist. Empirical work has shown that racial minorities and White Americans typically live in neighborhoods that are disproportionately coracial and attend schools that are even more segregated (Logan, Stowell, and Oakley, 2002; Reardon and Owens, 2017). Recent influxes in immigration among Latinos and Asian Americans have led to a resurgence in ethnic enclaves. And White Americans make up even smaller proportions of minority neighborhoods than they did just twenty years ago (Logan, 2011; Logan and Stults, 2011).

This segregation in American macrostructures—defined as the physical and institutional arenas that exist over multiple iterations of people (Lawler, Ridgeway, and Markovsky, 1993)—fosters social separation between individuals of different races. Macrostructures often provide the reasons for individuals to interact, giving them opportunities to come into contact with one another and form relationships (Lawler, Ridgeway, and Markovsky, 1993). If schools, neighborhoods, houses of worship, and other macrostructural institutions are disproportionately coracial, then so too will be the smaller, more intimate set of social ties that develop within them. For instance, Americans continue to have friends who are primarily the same race as themselves and are married to individuals who share their race (Lofquist et al., 2012; Marsden, 1987; McPherson, Smith-Lovin, and Cook, 2001). Even with increases in interracial marriage and interracial childbearing (Davenport, 2018; Tavernise, 2012; US Census Bureau, 2012), roughly 90% of Americans are married to samerace partners (Lofquist et al., 2012).

This racial segregation that exists, on average, in the United States today is not an inevitable arrangement of peoples but a reflection of political forces. Hundreds of years of American policy making have created racial categories as we understand them today. Through laws governing the flow of human bodies into the nation and restrictions on intermarriage, miscegenation, and citizenship, economic, legal, and social policy have produced macrostructures in the United States that sort and constrain individuals on otherwise apolitical traits (Katznelson, 2006; Haney Lopez, 2006; Massey and Denton, 1993; Omi and Winant, 2014; Trounstein, 2018). In a hypothetical world with a different political past, the social and geographic arrangement of peoples would be remarkably different.

p. 33 But in the nation as it exists today, Americans are sorted by racial group, and many people experience relatively high levels of embeddedness into these groups. This reality has implications for the development and enforcement of social norms. Others have shown that when social or geographic space is dense with in-group members, information is more accessible, trust tends to be higher, and observation is easier (DeSante and Perry, 2016; Larson and Lewis, 2017; Oliver, 2010). These are factors that collectively increase norm signals and the ability to dole out social rewards and sanctions for behavior (White and Laird, 2020). Segregation, too, magnifies the perception of differences between in-and out-group members and may increase the perceived impermeability of group boundaries (Enos, 2017; Tajfel and Turner, 1986). Under these circumstances, the stakes for acceptance by the group and the need to coordinate with other members increases precipitously. High levels of racial segregation, then, likely lead to increased norm-enforcement and compliance.

But segregation may also affect the *content* of group-based social norms, not just their strength and enforcement. Segregation, by definition, denotes that physical and/or social space exists between individuals of different groups. This space provides the opportunity for unique norms to emerge. Social norms develop in response to repeated interactions between individuals (Bicchieri, 2016; Meeussen, Delvaux, and Phalet, 2014), and these interactions are patterned by macrostructural forces (Lawler, Ridgeway, and Markovsky, 1993). By separating individuals of different groups, the encounters that lead to norms are also divided and will, over time, produce norm divergence.

Social separation, then, is a prerequisite for unique group-based norms to develop, but it is in and of itself an insufficient condition. Rather, for norms to develop differently across groups, incentives, constraints, and experiences *must also* diverge. These aspects of a group shape the content of norms, defining both what is normal and what is prescribed. Segregation provides the space for norms to develop and be enforced differently, but distinctiveness in group histories defines what exactly the norms are that form in this space.

Distinct Group Histories

p. 34 To even a naive observer of American history, it should be obvious that individuals of different races have faced distinct historical constraints and opportunities. From means of arrival to access to resources to share of political power, race has served as a fundamental dividing line in not just American politics but in American life (Dawson, 1994; Hutchings and Valentino, 2004; Takaki, 2008). To name just a few examples: American wealth—distributed with extreme inequalities—was built through the exploitation of non-White Americans over the course of centuries (Takaki, 2008). Exclusion from New Deal policies that created a middleclass (White) America meant Black Americans were denied the ability to unionize, buy homes, and attend universities (Katznelson, 2006). Drug policies designed in the 1970s and 1980s continue to have farreaching implications for Black and Brown communities (Alexander, 2012; Burch, 2013). And restrictive immigration laws that denied entry to almost all people living in Asian countries for more than a century have meant that the majority of Asian Americans in the United States today are relative newcomers (Masuoka and Junn, 2013).

Life in America is shaped profoundly by racial group membership, but possibly nowhere is this truer than in groups' relationship to their government. Government has been a primary force in deciding which groups get what and controlling the boundaries between peoples (Lopez, Passel, and Rohal, 2015; Trounstein, 2018). Government has withheld fundamental democratic rights from certain groups, provided clear economic advantages to others, and applied punitive powers unequally (Alexander, 2012; Katznelson, 2006; Keyssar, 2009; Lerman and Weaver, 2014; Takaki, 2008; Waters and Kasinitz, 2015). But a group's relationship to government is not only about what its members are denied; it is also about what they receive, from whom they receive it, and how policy outcomes are achieved (Bobo and Gilliam, 1990; Dawson, 1994; Gillion, 2013; Griffin and Keane, 2006). On each of these dimensions, racial groups also vary. Due to group size, resources, and unrestricted access to the franchise, some are able to achieve policy outcomes simply by engaging in the electoral process; others must turn to contentious political action in the form of protest to achieve social change (Fraga, 2018; Gilens, 2005). Furthermore, some racial groups have long and storied histories with political parties and organizations, while others are systematically overlooked in traditional mobilizing efforts (Dawson, 1994; Ramírez, Solano, and Wilcox-Archuleta, 2018; White, Laird, and Allen, 2014; Wong, 2008).

p. 35 These patterns of lived experience, shaped by legal constraints and animated by people's responses, make up the historical context of a group. It is this context that infuses membership with meaning. An individual's identity—the central building block of self in relationship to others (Tajfel and Turner, 1986)—is given content through the habits and values of a group that are built over time in response to environmental constraints and opportunities. Across the globe, all humans wear clothing, but what is fashionable depends on the group's climate and culture. Everyone eats, but cuisine varies widely by region. While segregation may provide the possibility for group norms to develop differently, groups must face unique opportunities and constraints, defined by their history, to observe norm variation.

An Inclusive Theory of Political Participation

We can join together what we've learned about the many elements of political participation—both the micro and macro—to generate a new theory and set of expectations about how social norms may affect the behavior not just of individuals but also of groups. The inherent costs involved in the participatory process inhibit engagement in politics, but selective rewards in the form of social and psychological incentives can counter these costs. The amount of social and psychological incentives available to individuals is shaped by the normative expectations of their groups. If groups are both socially separated from each other and have experienced distinct constraints and opportunities historically, then the content of social norms related to political participation is likely to vary. As a result, so too is the distribution of social and psychological rewards available for political participation, creating group-based patterns in engagement above and beyond those produced by costs alone.

Let us return momentarily to the four big participatory factors laid out by previous research we have discussed so far. The *benefits* available to groups who are able to influence the political process are widespread, but we know that Americans of different racial groups face variation in the *costs* they must overcome to engage in politics (Verba, Schlozman, and Brady, 1995). This includes the structural costs imposed or alleviated by political elites (Philpot and Walton, 2014; Ramírez, Solano, and Wilcox-Archuleta, 2018; Rosenstone and Hansen, 1993). We also know groups experience variation in the *probability that their engagement will matter* and their perception of this estimate (Bobo and Gilliam, 1990; Butler and Broockman, 2011; Fraga, 2018).

p. 36 Experiences with government ↵ can decrease political efficacy among certain groups (Lerman and Weaver, 2014; Soss, 2002) and their minority status means non-White Americans in many places are inherently at a disadvantage in the policymaking process (Fraga, 2018). We have also learned that social and psychological *selective incentives* that flow from social norms can help individuals overcome the inherent costs and uncertainty of the participatory process (Gerber, Green, and Larimer, 2008; McClendon, 2014; Salisbury, 1969).

To this robust literature, we now add a final piece: racial segregation and distinct group histories that constrain and create opportunity likely produce variation in the social and psychological incentives members of different groups face to participate. As a result, not only should costs and the perception that engagement matters shape outcomes across groups but so too should variation in participatory social norms and their enforcement. I call this theory of political participation the racialized norms model. It joins insight on the micro foundations of human behavior with the macrostructural components of American society to understand the forces that shape American political participation. Figure 2.1 presents its core elements visually.

Beginning from the left of the figure, we see that two macrostructural forces are at work. The first, historical group context, infuses membership with meaning and as we have learned, diverges based on racial group membership in ways likely relevant to participatory social norms. Distinct norms that may develop because of divergent histories are further reified by continued racial segregation—our second macrostructural consideration. Segregation by racial group provides space for norms to develop differently, increases the importance of group acceptance, and affects the ability of group members to sanction each other. As a result, geographic, social, or psychological embeddedness in a group—rather than just group membership—will shape the degree to which an individual confronts and adopts group-based norms.

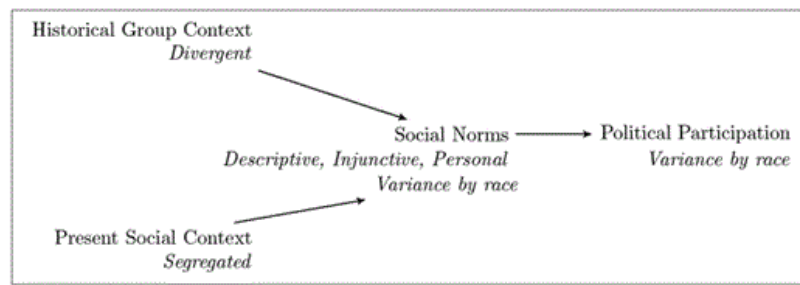


Figure 2.1 The racialized norms model

p. 37 This brings us to the second stage of the model. Macro forces of segregation and distinct group histories should affect all three types of social norms: descriptive, injunctive, and personal. In shaping the general habits and behaviors of a group, historical social context influences descriptive norms about the prevalence of participation within one's community. Racial embeddedness at the level of neighborhood, intimate social ties, or psychological group closeness should affect how easily individuals observe these behaviors and use them as cues for effective action. Historical context will also shape the normative prototypes of a group and the corresponding valued behaviors. Living in segregated social environments aids in the spread and enforcement of these injunctive norms, driven primarily by the threat of group-based social rewards and sanctions. Finally, over time external norms are internalized into personal norms—the core moral values that guide behavior and attitudes (Thøgersen, 2006). These norms affect individuals through the desire to avoid self-concept distress and are stronger when developed in a context with clear injunctive norms about what is morally right, good, and expected (Cialdini and Trost, 1998).

In the first and second stages of our model, segregated and divergent macrostructures lead to variation in norms about political participation. These norms should be thought of as encompassing the attitudes of individuals about the value and meaning of political participation and their willingness to sanction or reward others for engagement. In the third stage, we see how these norms affect participatory outcomes—namely, the choice to engage in politics. Individuals with strong personal norms about political participation should be most likely to engage. These personal norms—along with injunctive and descriptive norms—are expected to vary in their propensity across racial groups. Rather than just observing individual-level variation in participation, we should also observe group-level variation. And because racial segregation increases the intensity of these signals, we would expect these effects to be the strongest among individuals who are surrounded by coracial group members at the geographic and social levels or have a close psychological connection with their group.

p. 38 This broad theoretical framework produces a number of testable implications. First, historical differences in lived experiences should produce variation in the form and/or strength of social norms related to political participation. That is, groups should exhibit variation in both the norms they connect to political participation and the relative strength of those norms. These norms should vary both by racial group membership and by racial group embeddedness.

Second, political participation should be most likely to occur among those individuals who have internalized norms valuing political participation. Extant work shows that these integrated social norms are often the strongest predictors of behavior in prosocial settings (Thøgersen, 2006), but the propensity to internalize these norms should vary by group. Because of this variation in the strength of personal norms, and because of their importance in predicting political behavior, accounting for norms in models of political participation should reduce variation in involvement across groups.

The RNM further anticipates racial variation in the social and psychological pressures individuals confront to participate. But the ability of these pressures to influence observed behavior depends critically on other

elements of the equation as well—namely, costs. Structural barriers to participating in the form of resource constraints and inequities in mobilization also vary systematically by group (Philpot and Walton, 2014; Ramírez, Solano, and Wilcox-Archuleta, 2018; Verba, Schlozman, and Brady, 1995). To have a positive outcome, the selective benefits of participating—those social and psychological rewards for involvement in the process itself that we care so much about—must surmount the inherent costs. Because costs vary by group, the level of social benefits required to encourage participation among members is also variable. Groups with lower costs and smaller structural barriers require fewer selective benefits to reach a participatory outcome. In contrast, groups for whom participation is more costly—due to either lower resources or higher structural barriers—will require more selective benefits to reach the same outcome.

Third, group-based interpretations of the value and meaning of political participation will affect not just personal norms but also injunctive norms. This should be observable in the level of social rewards and sanctions groups dole out to those engaged in politics. Because we expect norms to vary by both racial group membership and racial embeddedness, we can expect to observe variation in the social rewards for political participation at the group level and by community context.

p. 39 Finally, social norms about the value and meaning of political participation ↵ should be able to be primed in ways that affect participatory attitudes and behaviors. Exposure to a cue that brings the social expectations of one's community to the fore should influence the degree to which an individual says participation is important, plans to engage, and commits to involvement. However, the effect of these priming cues should also be variable. Priming a norm that is not prevalent in one's community should produce little to no attitude and behavior changes. Furthermore, priming a norm among those who have already internalized their community's norms should have little effect on intention to engage. Rather, priming social norms about the value and meaning of political participation will be most likely to affect individuals who both occupy communities where the norm is prevalent and have not internalized the norm themselves. In these cases, external considerations, like cues from elites, rather than internal ones, can drive behavior.

Combining the macrostructures of American life with the micro mechanisms of human behavior leads us to anticipate variation in social norms with respect to participation by racial group membership and racial group embeddedness with far-reaching consequences for who shows up in the political sphere. But what exactly are these norms that matter for political participation? And how do they vary across racial groups in the United States? We turn to answering these questions next.

Notes

1. Building off Downs (1957), Riker and Ordeshook (1968) formalize this logic of voting with a simple equation: $R = (BP) - C$. Because costs of involvement (C) are ever-present and the likelihood that a citizen's vote decides the electoral outcome (P) is quite small, the differential benefit for the individual should their preferred candidate win (B) is overwhelmed. The result is predicted nonparticipation; the utility for not voting outweighs the utility of voting ($-R$). See Blais (2000) for a fuller treatise of this equation.
2. When visiting scholars gathered in Nashville to discuss a draft of my book, I was told that my manuscript reeked of a "happy-all-the-time" mindset. Many changes throughout now highlight, for instance, the ineffectiveness of participation and the pitfalls of evoking the past. Yet I remain ever inspired by people like John Lewis and Alice Paul who tirelessly wielded political action to craft a better world.
3. For a critique of this theoretical lens, see Green and Shapiro (1996).